

Why do social problems continue to exist despite politicians and stakeholders wanting to solve them?

Part of implementation evaluation is making sure that you are investing in the most efficient and effective way of addressing an issue. The Social Problem Cycle Tool (G18) helps clarify which types of services, policies and activities are invested in at different times for different social problems. The tool starts from the perspective that politicians and stakeholders aim to address social problems, seeking solutions that are broadly acceptable and considerate of the interests of key stakeholder groups. Where social problems continue, it may reflect the presence of significant challenges or concerns raised by influential stakeholder groups, whose perspectives are important to consider in the process.

The Social Problem Solving Cycle (G18) begins with a genuine desire to address a social problem due to the harm it causes. While solutions are sometimes developed quickly, these may not always fully address the complexity of the issue or lead to meaningful change.

In some cases, efforts go beyond initial responses by undertaking careful analysis to identify both the underlying causes and effective solutions to the social problem. These well-developed, evidence-based strategies may lead to the resolution or reduction of the problem. The diagram illustrates that, at times, evidence-based strategies may be perceived as difficult to implement, as they can impact the interests of stakeholders who are accustomed to the current situation.

As the cycle continues, such strategies may encounter resistance from stakeholders with differing priorities or perspectives, which can result in the reallocation of resources and, consequently, a failure to effectively address the problem with sufficiently robust evidence-based approaches. In such cases, because the issue remains unresolved, pressure continues to build for a solution, and the cycle begins again.